

Petite black lentil pâté

Though you can **substitute** green or brown lentils, look for the black variety, as they hold their shape well and offer a more distinct color. I strongly encourage you to **make this ahead** because the flavors build immensely over time. When ready, serve on crackers or fresh bread with goat cheese and mustard or horseradish, or maybe a little extra virgin olive oil.

1½ cups vegetable stock or water [375ml]

3 garlic cloves, minced

1 bay leaf

½ cup petite black lentils or French lentils
[100g]

½ onion, finely chopped

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

1 large portobello mushroom, chopped

½ cup broken or chopped walnuts [50g]

10 fresh green beans, cleaned of strings,
coarsely chopped

2 teaspoons dried basil

2 teaspoons dried oregano

1 teaspoon salt

½ teaspoon freshly ground black pepper

⅛ teaspoon crushed hot red pepper

1 tablespoon minced fresh rosemary

3 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

1. In a medium saucepan, **combine** the vegetable stock, garlic, and bay leaf. Bring to a boil. Add the lentils and reduce the heat to a simmer. Cover and cook for about 25 minutes or until the lentils are soft. Remove and discard the bay leaf.
2. Meanwhile, in a medium skillet, **cook** the onion in 1 tablespoon olive oil over medium heat until softened and beginning to color, about 5 minutes. Add the mushroom and walnuts and cook until the mushroom has released its juices and they have evaporated, 5 to 7 minutes longer.

3. Add the green beans, basil, oregano, salt, black pepper, and hot pepper. Continue to **cook** until the herbs are fragrant and the green beans have softened slightly, about 2 minutes longer. Add the fresh rosemary and 2 tablespoons lemon juice. Cook until the liquid is absorbed.
4. In a food processor, **blend** the onion-mushroom mixture until well mixed. Scrape down the sides to make sure all the ingredients have been well incorporated. Add the cooked lentils and mix again until very smooth. Add the remaining 1 tablespoon each lemon juice and olive oil. Mix well. Adjust the seasoning, if necessary. Let the flavors marry at least 2 hours before serving. If not eating for more than 1 hour, refrigerate. For best results, serve at room temperature.

SERVES 6 TO 8

note The color of the pâté will likely be grayish and muddy right after blending. But, no fear, this will also change over a couple of hours' time.

